



## Paying the price for not investing in our youth

### 不投资年轻一代的代价

难度评级：★★★★☆

#### 【 Para.1 】

Most people think Britain is not working as it should. For young people, the situation is at its most **acute**: only one in four believe that everyone in society has **a fair crack**. Most think the game is **rigged**.

大多数人认为英国社会当前的运转方式不合理。这种观念在年轻人身上尤为突出：他们中只有四分之一认为当前社会中的每个人都能获得公平的机会。大多数人认为这套体系是受操纵的。

#### 【 Para.2 】

It is clear why the generation who grew up in the post-2008 crash austerity years as well as Covid are **downbeat**: the level of public service provision their parents enjoyed is gone, living costs are rising, the AI revolution is changing everything, and the planet is on fire.

#### 文章导读：

英国年轻人大多认为社会体系运转不公平。大批英国年轻人处于无业状态。作者认为原因主要在于英国政府的紧缩政策，尤其是在过去16年间的教育等公共服务领域。这类公共服务领域的投资都遭到大幅削减。而对于青年无业现状，英国政府更多采取治标不治本的方法。这种方法给政府以及社会造成的损失惨重。但每一届政府都缺乏动力去采取有力措施。医疗系统或可以成为前车之鉴，作者认为英国政府必须下定决心，改变现状。

**acute a.** /ə'kju:t/ You can use acute to indicate that an undesirable situation or feeling is very severe or intense. 严峻的【考研大纲词汇】

The war has aggravated an **acute** economic crisis.  
这场战争加剧了一场严峻的经济危机。

**a fair crack of the whip idiom** (BrE informal) a reasonable opportunity to show that you can do sth (做某事的) 合理机会

I felt we weren't given **a fair crack of the whip**.  
我觉得我们没有得到合理的机会。

**rig v.** to arrange or influence sth in a dishonest way in order to get the result that you want (以不正当的手段) 操纵，控制  
SYN fix

He said the election had been **rigged**.他说选举被人操纵了。

**downbeat a.** (informal) dull or depressing; not having much hope for the future 沉闷的；令人沮丧的；悲观的

The overall mood of the meeting was **downbeat**.  
整个会场的气氛是沉闷的。

**miss out on phrase** to fail to benefit from sth useful or enjoyable by not taking part in it 错失获利（或取乐等）的机会  
【考研大纲词汇】

Of course I'm coming—I don't want to **miss out on** all the fun! 我当然要来—I可不想错失好玩的机会。

**building blocks n.** [pl.] parts that are joined together in order to make a large thing exist 组成部分；构成要素

Single words are the **building blocks** of language.  
单词是语言结构的基本单位。

**prosperous a.** /'prɒspərəs/ rich and successful 繁荣的；成功的；兴旺的【考研大纲词汇】

SYN affluent

**prosperous countries** 繁荣的国家

不难理解，为何在2008年金融危机后的紧缩年代以及新冠疫情期间成长起来的一代人会如此消极：他们父母那一代享有的公共服务水平已不复存在，生活成本不断攀升，人工智能革命正在改变一切，而地球正面临气候危机。

### 【 Para.3 】

That is why Alan Milburn's review into youth unemployment is vital. Britain **missing out on** the talents of 1 million young people not in education, employment or training (Neet) is a problem that extends beyond the jobs market. It is about how the **building blocks** of a just and **prosperous** economy have been **whittled away**, and is a call to action to put things right.

正因如此，艾伦·米尔本（Alan Milburn）关于青年失业的这份调查报告至关重要。英国目前有100万年轻人既未接受教育、也未就业或接受培训（即所谓的“NEET”），这部分群体的潜能并未得到理由——此问题已超出了就业市场的范畴。这关乎构建公正繁荣经济的基石如何被一点点侵蚀，同时也是对采取行动扭转局面的一种呼吁。

### 【 Para.4 】

As with so many of the country's problems right now, some of the big drivers of youth inactivity **stem from** the **austerity** years. That is not to say that other contributing factors – not least Labour's management of the economy, AI **upending** youth jobs, and the cost of living crisis – are not playing a role. But there is **mounting** evidence the consequences of the Tory spending cuts are **maturing** with

**whittle away v.** to make sth gradually decrease in value or amount 削减，减少，降低（...的价值或数量）

**stem from v.** (not used in the progressive tenses 不用于进行时) to be the result of sth 是...的结果；起源于；根源是【考研大纲词汇】

All my problems **stem from** drink.

我所有的问题都是酗酒引起的。

**austerity n.** /əˈsterɪti/ Austerity is a situation in which people's living standards are reduced because of economic difficulties. 经济紧缩

...the years of **austerity** which followed the war.

...战后的经济紧缩年代。

**upend v.** /ʌpˈend/ to turn sb/sth upside down 翻倒；倒放；使颠倒

The bicycle lay **upended** in a ditch.

自行车翻倒在一条小水沟里。

**mounting a.** /ˈmaʊntɪŋ/ [only before noun] increasing, often in a manner that causes or expresses anxiety 上升的；增长的【考研大纲词汇】

**mounting excitement/concern/tension**

越来越兴奋/关注/紧张

**mature v.** to become fully grown or developed 成熟；长成【考研大纲词汇】

Technology in this field has **matured** considerably over the last decade.

这一领域的技术经过过去十年的发展已经相当完善。

**disastrous a.** /dɪˈzɑːstrəs/ very bad, harmful or unsuccessful 极糟糕的；灾难性的；完全失败的【考研大纲词汇】

SYN catastrophic, devastating

a **disastrous** harvest/fire/result 严重歉收/火灾；灾难性的结果

**trace v.** ~ sth (back) (to sth) to find the origin or cause of sth 追溯；追究【考研大纲词汇】

She could **trace** her family tree back to the 16th century.

她能把本族家谱追溯到16世纪。

**instructive a.** /ɪnˈstrʌktɪv/ giving a lot of useful information 富有教益的；增长知识的

a most **instructive** experience 获益良多的经历

**across the board phrase** involving everyone or everything in a company, an industry, etc. 全体；整体；全面【考研大纲词汇】

The industry needs more investment **across the board**.

这一行业需要全面增加投资。

**stark a.** unpleasant; real, and impossible to avoid 严酷的；赤裸裸的；真实而无法回避的

SYN bleak

He now faces the **stark** reality of life in prison.

他现在要面对狱中生活的严酷现实了。

**disastrous** consequences..

与英国当前的许多问题一样，导致青年不活跃的一些主要驱动因素源于紧缩政策时期。但这并非在否认其他因素在其中的作用——尤其是工党对经济的治理、人工智能对青年就业的颠覆性挑战以及生活成本危机。但越来越多的证据表明，保守党削减开支的后果正在显现，并带来灾难性的影响。

### 【 Para.5 】

Milburn says the risk of a child becoming Neet can be **traced** to their earliest years in preschool. To look back, therefore, at the past 16 years of change in education policy, youth services and the public sector more broadly – the lifespan of the generation just entering the workforce – is **instructive**

米尔本指出，儿童未来成为“NEET”的风险可追溯至其学前期的早期阶段。因此，回顾过去16年间教育政策、青年服务以及更广泛的公共部门所发生的变化具有重要的启示意义——这恰好是眼下刚刚步入劳动力市场的这一代人的成长历程。

### 【 Para.6 】

**Across the board**, funding has been cut. Within youth services in England, spending is down by 76%, a loss of £1.3bn. Thousands of youth clubs have been closed and social workers lost. The per-pupil level of spending for schools in England was frozen for 14 years. Investment in school buildings, many of which have been affected by the Raac – or crumbling concrete – crisis, also collapsed by a quarter.

**shell out v. (informal)** to pay a lot of money for sth付（一大笔钱）【考研大纲词汇】

SYN fork out

The band **shelled out** \$100 000 for a mobile recording studio. 乐队花了10万元购置一间移动录音室。

**adrift adv. (of a person)** feeling alone and without a direction or an aim in life漫无目的；随波逐流；漂泊无依

young people **adrift in the big city**在大城市漂泊的年轻人

**shortsighted a.** If someone is shortsighted about something, or if their ideas are shortsighted, they do not make proper or careful judgments about the future. 目光短浅的

Environmentalists fear that this is a **shortsighted** approach to the problem of global warming.

环境保护主义者担心这会是解决全球变暖问题的一个目光短浅的方法。

**preventive a.** Preventive actions are intended to help prevent things such as disease or crime. 预防性的

Too much is spent on curative medicine and too little on **preventive** medicine.

在治疗医学上花费太多，而在预防医学上花费太少。

**fiscal a. /'fiskəl/** Fiscal is used to describe something that relates to government money or public money, especially taxes. 财政的【考研大纲词汇】

...in 1987, when the government tightened **fiscal** policy. ... 1987年，当该政府紧缩财政政策时。

**revitalise v. (=revitalize)** To revitalize something that has lost its activity or its health means to make it active or healthy again. 使恢复元气；使复苏

This hair conditioner is excellent for **revitalizing** dry, lifeless hair.

这种护发素对使干枯、无生气的头发重新焕发光彩非常有效。

**compelling a. /kəm'pelɪŋ/** that makes you think it is true 令人信服的【考研大纲词汇】

There is no **compelling** reason to believe him.

没有令人信服的理由让人相信他。

**hem sb/sth in v.** to surround sb/sth so that they cannot move or grow easily包围，限制（某人/某事物）

SYN hedge sb/sth in

The village is **hemmed in** on all sides by mountains.

村子四面环山。

She felt **hemmed in** by all their petty rules and regulations. 她觉得受到他们那些琐碎的规章制度的束缚。

**predicament n. /pri'dɪkəmənt/** a difficult or unpleasant situation, especially one where it is difficult to know what to do尴尬的处境；困境；窘境

SYN quandary

the club's financial **predicament**俱乐部的财政困境

总体来看，各领域投入的资金均遭削减。在英格兰，对青年服务的支出减少了76%，损失达13亿英镑。数千家青年俱乐部被迫关闭，大量社会工作者被裁减。英格兰学校的生均经费已经14年不曾增长。针对学校建筑的投资也骤减了四分之一，与此同时，许多学校建筑都受到了“Raac”（即混凝土风化）危机的影响。

### 【 Para.7 】

The situation is **stark** in the Neet crisis. For every £1 the state spends on employment support for young people, it **shells out** £25 on benefits. With the rise in inactivity for a generation cut **adrift**, the cost is only going to climb without intervention.

在“NEET危机”方面，形势尤为严峻。政府每在青年就业支持上花费1英镑，就要在福利金上支出25英镑。随着这一代被放任不管的青年中不活跃的比例不断增加，如果不采取干预措施，相关成本只会持续攀升。

### 【 Para.8 】

It is a pattern repeated across government. Rather than investing in public services early to stop problems from developing, the state is in firefighting mode. For Andy Burnham, the task will be to end this **shortsighted** approach by rebuilding what the thinktank Demos calls a **preventive** state – a model involving investment to support the foundations of society. The size of the economic, **fiscal** and social prize would be substantial.

这种模式在政府各部门中屡见不鲜。政府非但没有及早投资公共服务以遏制问题恶化，反而始终处于“救火”模式。对于安迪·伯纳姆而言，他的任务将是终结

**smaterialise v. (=materialize)** If a possible or expected event does not materialize, it does not happen. 实现

A rebellion by radicals failed to **materialize**.

激进分子的一次叛乱未能实现。

**sceptical a. /'skɛptɪkəl/** If you are sceptical about something, you have doubts about it. 表示怀疑的【考研英语大纲词汇】

Others here are more **sceptical** about the chances for justice being done. 这里的其他人更为怀疑正义能否得到伸张。

**favour v.** If you favour something, you prefer it to the other choices available. 更喜欢

**consequent a. /'kɒnsɪkwənt/** Consequent means happening as a direct result of an event or situation. 作为结果的

The warming of the Earth and the **consequent** climatic changes affect us all.

全球变暖以及随之而来的气候变化影响我们每个人。

**grasp the nettle idiom (BrE)** to deal with a difficult situation firmly and without hesitating 果断地处理棘手问题

**settle for v.** to accept sth that is not exactly what you want but is the best that is available 勉强接受；将就【考研英语大纲词汇】

In the end they had to **settle for** a draw.

最后，他们只好接受平局的结果。

**hamstring v. /'hæmstrʊŋ/ (hamstrung-hamstrung)** [often passive] to prevent sb/sth from working or taking action in the way that is needed 妨碍；使不能正常工作（或行动）

## ➤ 今日句子分析

主句 宾语从句

That is not to say that other contributing factors –

主语 系语 表语 从句主语

not least Labour's management of the economy, Al  
upending youth jobs, and the cost of living crisis –

列举同位语

are not playing a role.

谓语 宾语

这种短视的做法，重建智库“Demos”所称的“预防型国家”——一种通过投资来支撑社会根基的模式。此举在经济、财政和社会层面都将带来巨大的回报。

### 【 Para.9 】

The challenge for ministers is that the cost to the economy and to government finances of the Neet crisis is £125bn a year and rising. Getting more young people into work would, though, **revitalise** the life chances of millions and drive up labour participation – boosting the economy and public finances.

政府部长们面临的挑战在于，“NEET危机”给经济和政府财政造成的年度损失高达1250亿英镑，且仍在攀升。而让更多年轻人就业可以重振数百万人的生活机遇，并提高劳动力参与率——从而提振经济和公共财政。

### 【 Para.10 】

Before the autumn budget, there is a **compelling** argument for Burnham's government to take action. However, building a preventive state will come with challenges for a prime minister **hemmed in** by the UK's current tight fiscal **predicament**, and who is in a hurry to show progress.

在秋季预算案公布之前，现任伯纳姆政府有充分理由要对此采取行动。然而，对于一位受制于英国当前严峻财政困境、且急于展示进展的首相而言，构建预防型国家将面临诸多挑战。

### 【 Para.11 】

Moving money upstream is difficult because the savings

句子分析：

主句：

主句：

主语-That；系语-is；表语-not to say（that is to say “换句话说”，否定则指“但这不是说”，两种都是用来对前面的观点进行进一步的阐释）；

宾语从句：

（引导词）-that；从句主语-other contributing factors（“其他原因；影响因素”）；

列举同位语 -not least（=especially 尤其是） Labour's management of the economy, AI upending youth jobs（逻辑主语+动名词），and the cost of living crisis；

谓语-are not playing；宾语-a role（play a role “起作用”，例：A new study suggested that our short-term memory also may play a role in appetite. 一项新的研究表明，我们的短期记忆也可能对食欲产生作用。）。

## ➤ 写作积累

Para.3 It is about how the building blocks of a just and prosperous economy have been whittled away, and is a call to action to put things right.

building block的基础含义为“积木”，也可以喻指“构成……的基本要素”，文中这里便是取的比喻含义（且一般会以复数形式出现），补充例句：...molecules that are the building blocks of all life on earth. ...构成地球上所有生命的分子。

与之相近的表达还包括：

cornerstone n. “建筑中的奠基石” ⇨ “最重要的部分/基础”，例：This study is the cornerstone of the whole research programme. 此项研究是整个研究计划的基础。

ingredient n. “成分；材料；食材” ⇨ “基本要素”，例：It has all the ingredients of a good mystery story. 这部作品具有构成一个好的神秘故事所有的因素。

Para.8 Rather than investing in public services early to stop problems from developing, the state is in firefighting mode.

rather than一般指“而不是”（类似于instead of），通常用于强调前后对比。需要注意的是，rather than前后的两个句子成分在语法结构上要保持一致，这点和instead of不同，例如：Their main job is to preserve health rather than treat illness. 他们的主要职责是保健而不是治病。（前面是preserve原型，后面也要是动词原型，因此这里跟的是treat，而非treating）。文中这里主要是由于后面与之对照的是be in firefighting mode（be+名词短语），所以最合适的还是动名词investing in...。

至于这里的firefighting mode则需要根据上下文来理解，作者想借此讽刺政府的应对方式是一种被动、应急、只顾眼前的危机管理方式——哪里有“火情”（突发问题）就冲向哪里，完全没有精力和远见去做预防性工作。

from preventive spending take time to **materialise**, and spending on acute need and welfare cannot be simply turned off. Nowhere is this clearer than early-years services, where changes can take a lifetime to show up in the numbers.

将资金投入预防性措施颇具难度，因为预防性支出的节省效果需要时间才能显现，而针对紧急需求 and 福利的支出也无法简单“一刀切”。这一点在早期儿童服务领域表现得最为明显——该领域的改革效果可能需要一代人的一辈子才能在数据中体现出来。

#### 【 Para.12 】

That timing problem is why the Treasury has often been **sceptical**. The costs appear immediately, while the savings arrive years later – often benefiting a different government. The incentives **favour** firefighting over fixing.

正是由于这种时间差问题，财政部往往持怀疑态度。成本立竿见影，而节省的开支却要数年后才能显现——且往往由另一届政府来享受其红利。这种激励机制导致人们更倾向于“救火”而非“治

本”。

#### 【 Para.13 】

However, refusing to make the transition is a bad choice. Britain is already paying the price of a crumbling NHS, rising welfare bill, jobs market inactivity, and **consequent** weak economic growth.

然而，拒绝此类转型并不明智。英国已经在为国民医疗服务体系（NHS）的崩溃、不断攀升的福利开支、就业市场停滞以及由此导致的经济增长乏力付出代价。

#### 【 Para.14 】

Milburn's review is therefore a critical test of whether Britain will **grasp the nettle** to rebuild a preventive state from the ashes of the austerity years. The alternative is to **settle for** a country **hamstrung** by the costs of failure, where young people feel lost.

因此，米尔本的评估报告将成为关键试金石，检验英国是否敢于直面难题，在紧缩政策的废墟上重建一个注重预防的国家。否则，英国将沦为一个被失败代价所束缚、年轻人感到迷失的国家。